

MEMORANDUM

To: United States Government Officials

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Date: April 4, 2026

Subject: Trust in the Federal Government

Trust is what allows governments to govern effectively. When people believe their government is competent and acting in the public interest, they're more likely to follow laws, pay taxes, and comply with policies. When trust is low, the opposite happens and leaders are unable to perform duties efficiently.

This memo analyzes how race, income, and education are descriptively associated with trust in the federal government in the 2024 American National Election Studies (ANES) data set which samples political behaviors, attitudes and beliefs of voting age adults in the United States. The survey collects data through online, face-to-face, phone, and paper interviews. Combining results across modes may introduce response bias and increase the number of missing responses. The survey results may not represent groups that are unable to vote or who are not likely to vote.

The racial differences were small overall, but Hispanic and Asian/Pacific Islander groups showed statistically significant distinctions. Hispanic voters were 8 percentage points more likely to report trust than White respondents, and Asian/Pacific Islanders were 7 points more likely. It is important to note that while some racial groups are associated with modestly higher trust, the differences are relatively small in practical terms and should not be overstated.

Income showed no statistically significant association with trust in the federal government across any income bracket relative to those earning \$100,000 or more.

Educational attainment showed no statistically significant association with trust in the federal government compared to respondents with a high school diploma.

Adults 65+ were 6.8 percentage points more likely to report trust than those aged 45-64, and 13.3 percentage points more likely than those under 45.

Strong Democrats scored 18.3 percent higher in trust than strong independents. Independent-leaning Democrats scored 6.2 percent higher, which is a real difference but much smaller. Overall, the biggest takeaway is that strong Democrats stood out the most, while most other groups scored similarly to independents.

Robustness checks support our model choice. The LPM and logit models yield consistent signs, significance, and relative importance, indicating results are not driven by functional form. VIFs show low multicollinearity, and adding controls preserves key patterns, particularly for race, while attenuating others. Together, these findings suggest our conclusions are not driven by collinearity or omitted variable bias.

These findings suggest that trust in the government is most strongly shaped by party affiliation and age, while race shows small associations and income and education remain largely unimportant. Rebuilding public trust will require targeted engagement across political and generational lines, not just socioeconomic ones.

Appendix

OLS Regression Results: Predictors of Trust (Binary)

Dep. var.: trust_binary | N = 4,714 | Adj. R² = 0.093 | RMSE = 0.338 | SE: heteroskedasticity-robust

Variable	Estimate	Std. error	t value	p value	Sig.
Intercept					
(Intercept)	+0.096	0.023	4.100	< 0.001	***
Race ref: White, non-Hispanic					
Hispanic	+0.081	0.018	4.403	< 0.001	***
Asian/Pacific Islander	+0.070	0.030	2.321	0.020	*
Multiple races	+0.055	0.030	1.796	0.073	.
Black, non-Hispanic	+0.040	0.021	1.877	0.061	.
Native American/Other	+0.028	0.058	0.488	0.625	—
Age ref: 45–64					
65+	+0.068	0.014	4.858	< 0.001	***
18–29	−0.061	0.017	−3.686	< 0.001	***
30–44	−0.065	0.012	−5.448	< 0.001	***
Party ID ref: Strong Independent					
Strong Democrat	+0.183	0.022	8.389	< 0.001	***
Independent-Democrat	+0.062	0.022	2.765	0.006	**
Not very strong Democrat	+0.038	0.022	1.703	0.089	.
Not very strong Republican	+0.003	0.022	0.148	0.882	—
Independent-Republican	−0.035	0.020	−1.745	0.081	.
Strong Republican	−0.037	0.019	−1.907	0.057	.
Education ref: High school diploma					
Less than high school	+0.052	0.029	1.822	0.069	.
Graduate degree	+0.023	0.018	1.285	0.199	—
Bachelor's degree	+0.005	0.016	0.297	0.766	—
Some college/Associate	−0.025	0.014	−1.726	0.084	.
Income ref: \$100,000+					
Under \$25,000	+0.009	0.016	0.571	0.568	—
\$25,000–\$49,999	−0.011	0.016	−0.678	0.498	—
\$50,000–\$99,999	−0.003	0.013	−0.208	0.835	—

Sex ref: Male					
Female	-0.014	0.010	-1.374	0.170	—

Significance codes: *** p < 0.001 ** p < 0.01 * p < 0.05 . p < 0.1 — not significant

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